



Vodafone 150 at Rs.700

Vodafone is all set to launch the world's most cheapest handset at Rs.700 named Vodafone 150 which supports voice calling, SMS and mobile payment option.

Lian Li USB 3.0 Cabinet

Lian Li launched the world's first USB 3.0 cabinet named PC-A77F Full Tower Chassis which has 4 USB 3.0 ports.



Deepesh Agarwal wants to spread his cab-pooling service to Delhi and Bangalore

Shreyasi Singh

Last summer, when most students were preparing to leave the landscaped campus of Indian School of Business (ISB), Hyderabad in pursuit of high-flying corporate careers, Deepesh Agarwal and Amit Gupta were getting ready to test their "cabpooling" idea on the incoming batch.

Agarwal, who majored in entrepreneurship at ISB, was not willing to accept that shared transportation as a concept had failed in India. It was just not presented correctly, he believed. The hammer hit the nail bang on. "Our shared cab service was a hit. We had 120 students sharing 60 cabs, saving Rs 36,000 and 200 litres of petrol in a single day," he recounts. A quick market research carried out by the duo on 200 people in Delhi, Bangalore and Hyderabad, showed that the idea was worth pursuing in terms of business. The survey found that nearly 65 per cent of the people were willing to share a ride.

After some tweaking of the initial model, RideInSync was launched in September 2009. The service packaged the basic virtues of carpooling — dip in transport costs, congestion on the road and carbon footprints — along with the option of choosing co-passengers to and from a common destination. The entire service can be accessed through a mobile phone or laptop.

RideInSync

Share a cab, choose a partner, choke the jam

For instance, an ISB student taking a cab from the airport could send a text message to RideInSync to check whether any one else wanted to share the ride to the campus. It will match the flight and city details, and provide a list of passengers headed the same way.

The student can choose

a co-passenger, and a cab is arranged.

Making business out of a virtue is not easy and Agarwal knows that pretty well. But the numbers he throws up are pretty interesting. A shared ride from the airport to the city costs Rs. 250 between 5am and 11pm; and Rs. 300 from 11pm to 5am. A regular Meru cab or Radio Taxi would typically run up a bill of Rs 550 for the same trip.

"Our survey showed us that 50% of the cabs carry single passengers. Often, there are colleagues, neighbours or friends who live near each other and are going to the airport at the same time. If finding out who was heading which way was easily possible on a laptop or a mobile phone, wouldn't these people be interested in sharing cabs to save money, and to meet up with other like-minded people?" Agarwal asks.

Currently, RideInSync offers this service on a single route — to and from Hyderabad and its twin city Secunderabad to the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport.

"I knew this service had to be launched in Hyderabad or Bangalore. Since both these airports are so far from the city centre, the service offers immediate returns to our users," explains Agarwal.

While Bangalore and Delhi are the next expansion points, Agarwal wants to add to his list of destinations covered within the City of the Nizams. In fact, bringing the Hyderabad railway station

under his service radar is high on the priority list.

But before anything else, he knows he has to pull up the numbers on the airport pilot route. "We have 730 registered users right now, but the critical mass is around 5,000 members. This increases the probability of finding a partner to share a cab with. Currently, only 15% of the cabs booked on our platform are shared cabs because of the small user base. We also give our passengers the option to book a non-shared cab with us, if they are not able to find a partner," he says.

Agarwal, whose partner has since moved on to a job in Mumbai, is now thinking of tying up with big companies, such as Infosys and others to get more people to warm up to the idea of "cab pooling". "That should be a quick way to increase our strength," adds the first-generation entrepreneur, who worked with Motorola India as an engineering manager before deciding to join ISB in 2008.

The B-school network has helped tremendously. RideInSync works out of the Wadhvani Center of Entrepreneurship Development, ISB's Incubation Centre, with two other full-time employees — a master's graduate from IIIT Hyderabad and a software engineer from BITS Pilani.

So far, 80% of the Rs 5 lakh that Agarwal had put together from personal savings and borrowings from family has gone into developing the software platform. "I don't worry about this. It cannot stop me from realising what I want. Moreover, I am not looking for immediate funding. I don't want to sell my equity for cheap. I want to work on a stable cash flow," he says.

Whether RideInSync will become a pin-up darling of start-ups or run out of steam in the long run may be difficult to predict, but there is one thing for sure — Agarwal and Co. will save the planet a few extra carbon footprints and noxious fumes on their way to the bank. **E**